gathered pious men to find the will of God had not given up the search for Truth. He had only found it in himself.

When a man like Badauni, therefore, railed in his writings against Akbar's pretensions to prophethood – or worse – he did not accuse the emperor of being either cynical or insane. 'If Akbar's transgressions followed a certain cultural logic,' writes Moin, 'so did the accusations against him.' Badauni answered in Akbar's own coin. The emperor was not the Mahdi, no; nor was he mad.

Akbar was the Antichrist.

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It is a lot for a man to hold in his head, all these ideas and instincts, arguments and aspirations sparking in his brain. No wonder Akbar fainted.

It happened only days after he stopped the rain in Punjab. Remembering, perhaps, his last visit to the region, the emperor had ordered another grand qamargah hunt. While he camped near Bhera, his nobility formed a huge circle and drove in hordes of prey for Akbar to kill. But when the qamargah was ready, Akbar did not mount his horse and ride in joyfully with his cheetahs and spears, his lassos and guns. Instead, he had a seizure.

Akbar was possessed 'by a sublime joy', writes Abul Fazl.[6] Badauni is more forthright: 'a strange state and strong frenzy came upon the Emperor, and an extraordinary change was manifested in his manner'. It may have been an epileptic fit; it may have been a holy trance; and it was altogether unprecedented.

When Akbar recovered, he cancelled the hunt. There would be no spilling of blood today. Instead of prey, Akbar had ascetics and the poor gathered around him while he sat under a fruit tree and gave out gold. He also ordered a building and garden made at the spot; and, for himself, a haircut. It was now he declared why he'd grown his hair in the first place, 'from sympathy with the natives of India'. Was it not time
for others to adopt *his* style? The emperor shortened his 'long and beautiful' locks, and many courtiers followed suit, on the spot.[7]

News of the strange scene spread quickly.

Two years earlier, two young noblemen had crashed into each other during a game of polo; one fell to the ground and began to bleed. Akbar was part of